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13 Charles D. Maclean, *Manual of the Administration of the Madras Presidency*, 1885.

14 Here I am indebted to Sumathi Ramaswamy, *Passions of the Tongue: Language Devotion to Tamil India 1891–1970*, 1997, and Paula Richman, both for her own work and the essays edited by her in *Many Ramayanas: the Diversity of a Narrative Tradition*, 1991.

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16 Alexander Rea, 'Prehistoric antiquities in Tinnevelly', *ASI annual report* 1902–3, 1904.

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18 The poem's opening couplet compares the letter 'A', *akara* (the first letter of the Brahmi alphabet), to the Tamil noun *pakavan*. The English missionary George Pope, founder and for many years headmaster of Bishop Cotton School, Bangalore, in his English translation of the *Tolkappiyam*, published in 1886, translated *pakavan* as 'primal deity'. Jains have no problem with the concept of a supreme being in the form of a liberated human soul,